FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Getting old in India need not be the same anymore. The compulsion of sharing your living space with grown-up children is no longer a necessity. Nor do you need to live alone in a spartan religious commune with no material joy. There are options. There is a transformation that's unfolding in senior living spaces. We are used to the idea of 'old age homes' as an extension of the old idea of neglect. No rooms with a view, no golden sunsets. Instead, they are dreary, depressing places for those whose children have abandoned them. We certainly don't think of Rs 17 crore penthouses and 4BHK villas that cost Rs 5-6 crore. Scrolling down the menu of options, you can also score 1BHK units for about Rs 40 lakh. From lavish complexes with all the bells and whistles all the way to the more affordable ones that still cater to every need—places you can buy outright or rent. Yes, the boxes are all ticked: 24/7 nursing, doctors just an intercom call away, even panic buttons in every room if you so fancy.

But it goes much beyond mere assisted living. What we are seeing is a redefinition of old age itself. One part of this is a definite shift in social psychology. With rising life expectancy and greater disposable incomes, the seniors are no longer seen as just a dead weight, a part of the population sunk in passivity. Nor does their self-image conform to that old cliché. Rather, as active seekers of fulfilment, they have become the agents of their own change. Though the market presently addresses only those who can afford it, fact is that this so-called tiny sliver is itself quite big. As Dr Rana Mehta, partner and healthcare leader at PwC India, points out, explaining the evolution of the elder market over the past 5-10 years: "The first generation of seniors who accumulated wealth during the post-liberalisation period of the 1990s has entered this demographic."



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Normally, everyone associates trends and trendy things with the young. And elderly people live behind a mist of social neglect. We are breaking that stock picture because of a vibrant phenomenon: there's a big bazaar growing around growing old. Call them 'The Goldies', and the economy around them a Gold Rush for the Old. This is not merely a bubble. It will be a fully sustainable, robust segment of our social and economic life. One estimate by consultancy firm PricewaterhouseCoopers says the elder economy is already a $10-15 billion market in India. And it seems all set to grow at a rollicking 13-15 per cent yearly. This buzzing marketplace, full of eager buyers and sellers, involves not only what you would have expected in another era: things related to healthcare and assisted living. Instead, what we have before us is an explosion of products across a wide terrain that takes in everything from fancy habitats to plush lifestyle products, exciting travel options to assistance on financial and technology services, besides a myriad of everyday conveniences. All are geared towards the elderly.

The reasons for this phenomenon are the breakdown of old joint family structures, the shift to nuclear families in constricted urban spaces and job-related migration. The change in the infrastructure of society had made this boom inevitable. Anecdotally, all of us are familiar with the trend without having precise figures for it. The official Longitudinal Ageing Study of India's 2021 data says as many as 26 per cent of our elderly live with their spouse or alone away from their children. However, the idea of shifting to a conventional old-age home invariably evoked extreme reluctance because of that stigma. The arrival of new-age spaces has broken that mindset. These are objects of desire, not open-air prisons you check into with an air of being resigned to fate.

Senior Associate Editor Sonal Khetarpal surveys this new landscape for our cover story this week. She sees an overall increase in spending by and for the old. It is no surprise that entrepreneurs have taken notice of this emerging customer base. Eventually, India's demographic pattern will shift. With longer lifespans, the teeming young of today will make up a significant silver population as they age, even as declining fertility rates will mean fewer young people. According to the United Nations Population Fund, by 2050, some 347 million, or over 20 per cent of our population, will be above 60. And the elderly will outstrip the 0-14 demographic by the end of this century. A readymade growing market. So, expect investments to grow in tandem.

We visited some of the most well-appointed senior living spaces to get a feel of what it is like for the denizens. At Dehradun's Antara Senior Living, for instance, we came across affluent people who have chosen to shift here as a matter of enhanced convenience, not necessity. Like the octogenarian Anil and Seema Sud, who moved in two years ago from their spacious five-room house in Gurugram. Anil Sud, a former MD at EMI/ HMV, says it's just easier to outsource all the worries and have a button to press for everything.

Besides accommodation, there is also on the table a range of other services, from holidays to financial planning to technology. There are gadgets relevant to the needs of the elderly. Take wearable personal security devices with GPS trackers and SOS buttons, smart pill dispensers, pocket-sized medical devices that measure vital signs and hook up the results for remote diagnostics, "easyfones" that can be configured remotely by family members, AI-powered smart lamps that trigger an emergency response in case the senior has a fall and is unable to get up.

This is News You Can Use—applicable to all, bar none. Old age is a station that everyone is eventually going to arrive at. And everybody caught in mid-journey has old parents to fret about. But most of all, this is about breaking the pattern of India's elderly needing to be taken care of by their kids. We are witnessing the arrival of the Goldies, those who are taking charge of their lives and living it with robustness, grace and a lot of style. And three cheers to them!



(Aroon Purie)